approval to remove the missiles could be obtained from either NATO or Turkey before Monday.[9]

John Kennedy kept pushing. “To be reasonable, we’re not going to get these weapons out of Cuba, probably anyway—but I mean, by negotiation. We’re going to have to take our weapons out of Turkey. I don’t think he’s not going to [remove missiles from Cuba]—now that he made that public,” said Kennedy, turning to Llewellyn Thompson. “I don’t agree, Mr. President,” came the answer. As the discussion dragged on, Robert Kennedy saved the situation by telling his brother, “Why do we bother you with it, Mr. President? Why don’t you let us work this out?” The president responded that indeed they had to move on to other topics, but they also had to decide on his response to Khrushchev. “Why don’t we try to work it out for you without you being there to pick it apart?” responded Robert. Everyone laughed. The matter was relegated to a drafting committee without being decided in principle.[10]

It was the first time during the crisis that Kennedy had faced such strong opposition from his own aides. Unlike the members of Khrushchev’s Presidium, who were formally equals of the Soviet leader and had the same voting rights, the members of ExCom were there to advise the president and serve at his pleasure. But they exercised much more freedom in defending their positions than Khrushchev’s colleagues could ever have dreamed of. Aides, however, were only part of Kennedy’s problem. The Joint Chiefs of Staff were also in opposition to him, and with the Cubans now starting to shoot at American planes, Kennedy was at the mercy of his military commanders and developments on the ground that were beyond his control.

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THE INFORMATION THAT KENNEDY AND HIS AIDES RECEIVED during the afternoon session of ExCom from the Pentagon was alarming: antiaircraft batteries in Cuba were now shooting at low-flying American reconnaissance planes, forcing some of them to turn back. McNamara believed that if fire continued the next day, the US Air Force “must attack back, either the SAMs and/or MIG aircraft that would come against them or